DOCUMENTARY

THE BEST SHOT





Cinematographers have for long been the unsung heroes of Hindi films. Hemant Chaturvedi's new documentary finally brings his fellow lensmen into the spotlight

After more than a few unsavoury experiences on set, Hemant Chaturvedi quit his job as a cinematographer in 2015. "I was under a lot of pressure, and I'd been feeling disenchanted for a long time by then. The politics, the dishonesty and the quantum of nonsense just became too much," says Chaturvedi over the phone. After sharing an emotional Facebook post, Chaturvedi drove off to Lonar lake. Sitting by its edge for about 10 days, he contemplated his future. Since he still had a lot of questions about cinematography, Chaturvedi rang up a few veterans and requested some FaceTime with them. Fortunately for him (and us), most of them readily agreed.

Ranging from Peter Pereira (*Coolie, Shahenshah*), Jehangir Chaudhry (*Holi, Being Cyrus*) and Govind Nihalani (*Aakrosh, Ardh Satya*) to Baba Azmi (*Arjun, Mr India*) and Nadeem Khan (*Gaman, Disco Dancer*), Chaturvedi recorded conversations with 14 of the 17 veteran cinematographers he had intended to work with in 1990-91. "Everyone spoke for two hours each and we got almost 40 hours of footage," Chaturvedi says. These interviews culminated in *Chhayaankan: The Management of Shadows*—a 138-minute masterclass on the ins and outs of cinematography in Indian films.

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The film is a delightful love letter to a bygone era, but also a chilling documentation of disillusionment with an industry where even the most gifted technicians get little appreciation. "The day I finished the interviews, I realised my decision to move on was probably the best one I'd taken in my life. Twenty years on, I didn't want to be that person who is still hoping to find glory one last time. *Kuchh nahin hone wala*, boss!" says Chaturvedi.



By his own admission, Chaturvedi took longer to edit the film than he would have liked. Reading the news about Ishwar Bidri's (*Damini, Border*) passing and Nadeem Khan being in a coma for nearly two years, he suddenly realised most of his interviewees were 80-plus. "I went into panic and realised that if my own 'characters' don't see the film, then it would be sinful," says Chaturvedi. He dug through the footage to come up with 24 timelines for the questions he had asked. After that, Chatur-

DIGITAL ARCHIVE

FROM THE OUTSIDE IN

An archive of Indo-German journalist Navina Sundaram's work promotes a new internationalism

Documentary filmmaker, editor, and Indo-German journalist Navina Sundaram comes from a family of artists who have shaped the landscape of art and culture in India. Her grandfather, Umrao Singh Sher-Gil, the eldest son of Raja Surat Singh of Majithia, was born into the Punjab aristocracy. He was also a scholar of Sanskrit and Persian and was considered to be one of the pioneers of photography in India. Amrita Sher-Gil, a pioneer of modern Indian art, is Sundaram's aunt. And her brother, Vivan Sundaram, is one of India's foremost visual artists.

The Fifth Wall, a digital archive of Sundaram's body of work culls over 40 years of her work in public television. Created by Berlin-based novelist, screenwriter and film producer Merle Kröger and multimedia artist Mareike Bernien, it features films, reports, texts, letters, photographs and annotations. The archive, largely in German and available to browse online (die-fuenfte-wand.de), serves both

